

BOLLYWOOD

An Extended Interval

The IPL and the General Elections have hit Bollywood hard. On top of that, it has to deal with weak content

BY JOSHICA MADNANI

► **THE HINDI FILM** industry is facing a torrid time. If the impact of the Indian Premier League (IPL) has been managed over the years, it has to contend with the General Elections this year. Success rates of Bollywood films have dropped, coupled with a perception that the quality of content has taken a back seat.

Let's start with the IPL. It starts in mid-March and goes on till late-May. For viewers, it is a toss-up between watching a match at home or dealing with traffic to watch a movie in a the-

DOUBLE WHAMMY

A combination of the IPL and the General Elections has dealt a big blow to the Hindi film industry this summer

atre. On top of that, the later part of the IPL coincides with schools' summer vacations, a time film producers try to cash in on.

Manoj Desai, ED of Mumbai-based G7 multiplex and Maratha Mandir, admits to the IPL having had an impact over time. "When a match is at 7 pm, it harms all the evening shows. If it's on a weekend with two matches, both the afternoon and evening shows are hit," he rues.

Film critic and trade analyst Taran Adarsh admits that the polls have had a negative impact on movie releases and the industry. But there is a bigger problem, says Desai. "This year, movies failed because of bad content," he says. Between Diwali 2023 and Holi 2024, 57 Hindi films were released, but only Ranbir Kapoor-starrer *Animal* turned out to be a blockbuster. In recent months, two big-budget films bombed. *Bade Miyan Chote Miyan*, made on a budget of ₹350 crore and featuring Akshay Kumar and Tiger Shroff, grossed just ₹64.5 crore five weeks after its release, according to *sacnilk.com*, which tracks box office collections. The other dud was the Ajay Devgn-starrer *Maidaan* that was made on a budget of ₹250 crore and grossed less than ₹50 crore five weeks after its release, per *sacnilk.com*.

For Bollywood, poor content and viewers having many options to choose from are a recipe for failure. As things stand, Bollywood is hoping that the next set of big films—including *Baby John*, *Mr. and Mrs. Mahi*, and *Savi: A Bloody Housewife*—fare better at the box office, as these will be followed by *Kalki 2898 AD*, made with a jaw-dropping budget of ₹600 crore and starring Amitabh Bachchan, Prabhas, and Deepika Padukone. Trade analyst Komal Nahta says producers try their best to balance a release taking into consideration several factors. But "good content always has a way of attracting the audience". A simple piece of advice that is much needed now. **BT**

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